lakh and seventy thousand Indians who supported the Federation Party were side-lined. According to intelligence reports drafted immediately after Fiji's independence, distrust between the two major ethnic groups was deeply rooted in cultural differences. An uneven distribution of wealth and power had aggravated the situation. Fijians had moved into the modern economy very slowly and many felt their progress had been blocked by the better-educated and generally, more prosperous Indians who controlled much of the country's trade and finance. CIA analysts believed that the British would almost certainly oppose any electoral reforms that would provide power to the Indian majority. This is what the USA intelligence analysts observed in 1970:

The question of land ownership also threatens to disrupt racial harmony. Under British rule, more than four over five of Fiji's land area was reserved for tribal ownership, with the balance mainly owned by Europeans and the government. Indians, although constituting about 50 per cent of the population, own less than 2 per cent of the land area. While Indians produced most of the country's cash crops, most of their output comes from land leased mainly from Fijians. The problem is that while Indians want access to additional land, many Fijians feel the Indians already farm the best areas and want to maintain present restrictions on land ownership. Indeed, some Fijians are refusing to renew leases, and a 1967 law designed to protect tenants (Indians) has recently been under review with an eye towards limiting their rights.

The first Fijian Prime Minister, Ratu Mara, essentially a tribal chief in the Lau Island group of the South Pacific island nation, was an opportunist. Intelligence reports suggest that Mara joined the British colonial service in Fiji in 1950 and rose to